Jeremy Fink and the Meaning of Life

By Wendy Mass

JEREMY: **(Preface, Pg i-iii)** [Hi] I'm Jeremy Fink, a city kid born and bred, and my sweat *(sniffs armpits)* smells like peanut butter. I'm such a picky eater, my mother feeds me peanut butter sandwiches at every meal. So now when I sweat, it smells like peanut butter instead of B.O. *(smiles proudly)* My best friend, Lizzy, is a notorious troublemaker. She has a lot of opinions, usually negative. For example, she thinks my collection of mutant candy is gross. I think she's jealous because she didn't think of it first. The best is a peanut M&M the size of my pinky finger. I bet I could get a fortune for that one on eBay.

Today is my thirteenth birthday. If my father had spen[t] his thirteenth birthday playing Little League, I would be here. Instead, all those years ago, my father wandered down the Atlantic City boardwalk and wound up in front of an old palm reader. She picked up his hand and held it to her face and said

PALM READER: *(in a Russian accent)* "You vil die ven you are forty years old."

JEREMY: The prediction was wrong. My dad didn't die when he was forty. He was only 39. But Dad must have taken the prophecy seriously, because he prepared for his death, and this box proves it. *(Picks up the box from a nearby table and reads the inscription)* THE MEANING OF LIFE: FOR JEREMY FINK TO OPEN ON HIS 13TH BIRTHDAY. I never would have guessed, when Lizzie and I [were] given the box a month ago, that those instructions would be so impossible to follow.

*****

(Pg 4) *(NICK, the mailman, enters wheeling his huge blue cart)*

LIZZY: *(Saluting)* Howdy, Nick

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

NICK: *(tipping his hat)* Well if it isn't Lizzy Muldoun and Jeremy Fink. Let's see what I've got for you guys today. *(Nick reaches into his cart and lifts out a box)*

LIZZY: **(Pg 7)** *(Takes the box from Nick, who exits) (she reads the return address label aloud to Jeremy)* Folgard and Levine, Esquires.

JEREMY: *(takes box from Lizzy, opens the box and finds another wooden box inside. He reads the inscription)* **(Preface, Pg 13)** THE MEANING OF LIFE: FOR JEREMY FINK TO OPEN ON HIS 13TH BIRTHDAY? **(Preface, Pg iii)** *(to audience)* This box has come to symbolize all my hopes, all my failures. Before I do anything else, I need to go back over everything that happened this summer.

INTRODUCTION

Jeremy Fink collects mutant candy, won't go more than four blocks from home if possible and he definitely doesn't like surprises. But this year for his birthday he has one doozy of a surprise.

See, Jeremy is supposed to open this gift from his father on his birthday, but there's one problem. 4 keys are required to open the box, 4 keys are needed to discover the MEANING OF LIFE. But the keys are missing. Jeremy and Lizzy set off to find the keys, but what they don't know is that there might be other ways to find out the meaning of life.

Jeremy Fink and the Meaning of Life by Wendy Mass

JEREMY: **(Pg 32)** [The first thing we do is] take the box to Larry's Locks and Clocks to see if he can do anything. *(Jeremy and Lizzy enter the shop to find Larry, a thin man in overalls wiping his hands on a napkin)*

LARRY: **(Pg 34-35)** What can I do for you today?

LIZZY: Can you open this? *(plopping the box on the counter)*

JEREMY: I've lost the keys *(Larry examines the box with furrowed brow, then rests his hands on the box, eyes closed)* So . . . do you think you can open it for us?

LARRY: **(Pg 36-37)** *(eyes snapping open)* Nope. This is no ordinary box. Sorry to disappoint you, but the only way anyone is getting into this box is with the keys. *(Lizzy and Jeremy take the box and leave the store)*

JEREMY: **(Pg 33)** *(to Lizzy)* Okay. If the locksmith can't help us, we have to go to . . . the

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

flea market! *(to audience)* **(Pg 44)** The flea market is basically two big parking lots that smells like a combination of boiled hot dogs and sweat. And not the good, peanut butter kind of sweat. *(Sniffs armpits again, then they set off to find a vendor of old keys. They approach a vendor)* **(Pg 47)** We're looking for some old keys. Do you have any?

VENDOR: *(rummages around under a table and finally finds a box)* **(Pg 54)** You're welcome to go through my collection and see what you can find.

JEREMY: **(Pg 48)** *(Lizzy and Jeremy look in the box)* Um, these aren't exactly what we had in mind.

VENDOR: Huh? Why not?

LIZZIE: Well, for one thing, they aren't keys. They're locks.

VENDOR: Is that right *(she peers into the box)* Oops, sorry 'bout that. Keys, locks, all part of the same thing, right? *(She laughs a bit and then wanders off to help another customer)*

LIZZY: **(Pg 40)** Our best bet [was] the flea market. *(thinking hard and then lights on an idea)* **(Pg 160-161)** This morning, I told Rick and Samantha about your box and how we can't find the keys.

JEREMY: You did WHAT!??

LIZZY: Well, I'm glad I did because Samantha had a really great idea . . . . she said we should ask your dad!

JEREMY: What are you talking about? Didn't you tell her?!

LIZZY: Of course, I told her. Samantha said we can hold a séance. She has a Ouija board and everything. It's worth a shot.

****

(Pg 163-166) *(Lizzy and Jeremy go to Samantha and Rick's apartment (they are 14-year old twins), ring the bell and Samantha answers)*

SAMANTHA: Come on. We have the Ouija board set up in the living room. *(They follow*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Samantha to the living room where Rick is waiting)

JEREMY: *(rolling his eyes as he sees Rick)* Rick, [why are you] wearing a cape??

RICK: Samantha made me. She said if I didn't wear it and we couldn't contact your father, it would be all my fault. So . . . *(turns and elaborately displays his cape)* I'm wearing it.

SAMANTHA: *(in a hushed tone as she lights candles)* We are ready to begin. Everyone join hands. We are calling upon the spirit of. . . *(Out of the corner of her mouth, she whispers)* What's your dad's name?

JEREMY: *(also whispering)* Daniel Fink

SAMANTHA: . . . the spirit of Daniel Fink. Mr. Fink, (releasing hands and placing her fingers on the Ouija board pointer) if you can hear the sound of my voice, please send us a sign. *(A horn honks outside, and Samantha responds enthusiastically)* Thank you! O great spirit of Daniel Fink, we call upon you to answer our plea. Please tell us where we can find the keys to the box you left for *(she whips her head to gaze penetratingly at Jeremy)* Jeremy. *(They wait expectantly for the pointer to move . . . . nothing)*

LIZY: *(to Jeremy in a whisper)* Do you feel anything?

JEREMY: *(frustrated and exasperated, he removes his hands from the pointer and stands up)* Yeah . . I feel like an idiot! This is ridiculous! *(changing his tone and trying to sound sincere – To Samantha)* You were great. I'm not sure I really believe it's possible to contact my dad. But thank you for trying. *(He picks up his birthday box and as he exits)* I know you were only trying to help. *(to audience)* **(Pg 170)** I have only myself to blame . . . and maybe Lizzy. Definitely Lizzy.

******* The next day ********

LIZZY: **(Pg 158-159)** *(storming into Jeremy's bedroom and yanking open the blinds)* Come on. It's eleven o'clock already. *(She spies a lump in Jeremy's bed)* Is that lump next to you your dad's box? *(no answer – she reaches over and throws back*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

the blanket) It IS the box! *(She picks it up)* So you're sleeping with it now?

JEREMY: *(softly and shaking his head)* I need to figure out my purpose. Until I do, what's the use of getting up. I can't face the world until I know why I'm here.

LIZZY: You're kidding me! You can have your existential crisis – whatever that means – once you are out of bed. I'm pretty sure you won't find your purpose lying there. Get up! . . . **(Pg 59)** Our keys are hidden in the office of **(Pg 7)** Folgard and Levine, Esquires. We're gonna get into that office, and we're gonna find them.

JEREMY: *(leaping out of bed and grabbing the box from Lizzy)* Breaking and entering? That's your big plan?

LIZZY: **(Pg 60)** *(excited)* That's the spirit!

*****

(Pg 86-87) *(Lizzy and Jeremy cautiously enter the offices of Folgard and Levine, Esquires)*

LIZZY: *(in a whisper)* Let's get moving. You look in the office *(pointing in that direction)* and I'll check out here in the waiting area.

JEREMY: *(exploring the office, opening drawers, cabinets, etc)* Hey, Lizzy *(shouting as loud as he dares)* I might have found something!

LIZZY: **(Pg 89-90)** *(rushing in, to peer over Jeremy's shoulder)* See anything?

JEREMY: *(disappointed)* [Just] Pipes, dust and wires. *(He closes the cabinet, then turns and sees a very round and re-faced policeman standing next to Lizzy – he reacts in fear and raises both hands above his head)* . . . Officer? *(his voice cracks on the last word)*

OFFICER: **(Pg 91)** Would you like to tell me what you were doing? Breaking and entering is a very serious offense, you know.

JEREMY: **(Pg 92-93)** *(to audience)* Office Polansky makes us tell him our real names and addresses . . . and he types them into his computer. He is a very slow typist. *(to Lizzy in a whisper)* You ***swore*** we wouldn't get arrested!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

LIZZY: *(to Jeremy – forgetting to whisper)* We're not getting arrested! *(to the Officer)* Are we?

OFFICER: No, I'm not going to arrest you. I was thinking of community service. You don't have any big plans this summer, right?

JEREMY: *(to audience)* Great. How am I going to open the box if I can't look for the keys because I will be too busy picking up garbage on the West Side Highway or planting flowers in some church garden. **(Pg 265)** It was hopeless . . . [but then my 13th birthday arrived and everything changed!] . . . **(Pg 258)** I feel OLDER!

*****

(NOTE: Original text states: Mom and Lizzy come in, singing the happy birthday song)

MOM: Happy birthday to you!

LIZZY: Happy birthday to you!

MOM: Happy birthday dear Jeremy . . .

LIZZY: Happy birthday to you.

MOM: *(clapping and cheering)*

LIZZY: **(Pg 263-265)** Are you ready for my gift now? *(She pulls out a small box and hands it to Jeremy. It's not wrapped and Jeremy opens it, reaches inside and takes out a set of keys)*

JEREMY: *(Eyes stretching so far open they hurt)* Is this . . . Is this the . . . Is –

LIZZY: Yup! *(bouncing up and down with excitement)* It's the key(s)!

JEREMY: But how did you, where did you, how . . . . *(anger building)* All this time I've been thinking it was hopeless. But you knew. You knew!

LIZZY: *(uncertainly, she looks at Jeremy's Mom. Mom winks at her encouragingly)* The harder something is to acquire . . . the more satisfying it is when you finally find it . . . (sadly) I just wanted to give you a present you'd never forget.

NARRATOR (Mr. Oswald): **(Pg 281)** It's amazing how people will play along for a good

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

cause. [NOTE: in the original text this line is spoken by Mr. Oswald, a character that has been cut from this selection.]

***** Flashbacks******

NICK: **(Pg 4)** Let's see what I've got for you guys today. *(Nick reaches into his cart and lifts out a box)*

LARRY: **(Pg 36-37)** . . . the only way anyone is getting into this box is with the keys.

VENDOR: **(Pg 48)** Oops, sorry 'bout that. Keys, locks, all part of the same thing, right?

OFFICER: **(Pg 91)** Breaking and entering is a very serious offense, you know.

*****

JEREMY: **(Pg 282)** *(to Lizzy)* You did all this for me? Why would you do that?

LIZZY: **(Pg 268)** What are you waiting for??

JEREMY: Maybe we shouldn't open it. Maybe we weren't' supposed to find the keys after all. Let's just toss the box.

LIZZY: *(shouting)* Are you SERIOUS!!

JEREMY: Nah. Let's open it! *(Jeremy uses the keys to open all four locks on the box and it opens) (To audience)* **(Pg 269-273)** [It's] and envelope with my name on it. Trying, and failing, to keep my hands from trembling, I open it. Dear Jeremy. *(as Jeremy reads, we hear his dad's voice)*

DAD'S VOICE: As I write this you have just had your eighth birthday. I hope I am there beside you on your 13th birthday to tell you all this myself. If I'm not, I hope you can feel that I am always with you.

[It's been] 25 years since that fortune-teller in Atlantic City gave me such a dire prediction. I asked my father – your grandfather – if someone could really predict another person's future. He said the future changes every day. He said we, not someone else, have the power to create our own lives.

[Since that day] I made sure to pay attention to everything I was doing. To be

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

fully in the moment. Because that's all life is, really, a string of moments that you knot together and carry with you. It is something no one can ever take away from you. It will protect you and guide you, because it IS you.

Ralph Waldo Emerson wrote: "Most of the shadows in this life are caused by our standing in our own sunshine." Wisdom is found in the least expected places. Always keep your eyes open. Don't block you own sunshine. Be filled with wonder. Life is all about the journey. I hope this was one you'll never forget. I love you, Jeremy.

JEREMY: *(Looks up from his letter with tears in his eyes)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Wendy Mass
ISBN: 978-0316058292
Publisher: Little, Brown Books for Young Readers
Date (Month/Year): Nov 2006

AWARD HISTORY

2018 National Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY